

Pathology of POWER

| By Prabhu Chawla |

In normal times, Mohammed Mukarram Pasha's misdemeanour would have landed him in temporary police custody. The 19-year-old first year Commerce student in Bangalore would have been just another speedbiker with a challan had he not ignored police appeals. Instead, he sped away and took refuge on the terrace of a brigadier's house in the high security flagstaff locality from where he tried to call his family, speaking in Urdu. These are abnormal times and nobody takes chances; not certainly the guards outside the brigadier's house who, fearing a Mumbai being repeated in Bangalore, shot him dead. It's a fear that ordinary citizens have been living with for long—that their next visit to the market, the school or the bus terminus could be their last. But unlike the security forces, ordinary citizens don't have the luxury of service rifles.

In the year gone by, fear has been all pervasive. And nowhere more pronounced than amongst our ruling classes. Pasha's fate was just an indication of the extent to which fear

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